



Stepping stone: Tejaswin says that competing in the NCAA is like a stepping stone for the Commonwealth Games, Asian Games, or even the Olympics. In his first indoor season, he got a chance to compete against Koitaiti Kidali from Kenya (in pic, red), who competed at the Paris Olympics in the 800m. GETTY IMAGES

talent," says Bob Thurnhoffer, who initially attempted to recruit Lokesh Sathyanathan to the University of New Mexico and who recently recruited triple jumper Sharvari Parulekar to the University of Louisville.

Reluctant athletes

When competing at a high enough level, there's a good chance athletes will receive recruitment offers directly from colleges and coaches themselves.

Lokesh Sathyanathan says he got his first recruitment offer right after the Junior World Championships in Tampere, Finland, where he competed in the men's long jump. "At that time, a few coaches asked me if I was interested in coming here, getting a full ride and pursuing my studies and track as well," he says.

Lokesh had declined the offer back then.

It's something Tejaswin has seen happen on multiple occasions. "The biggest problem is that athletes in India are not confident enough to

leave their comfort zone. Sometimes coaches don't want to let them leave. They think that they are doing well in India, so why should they go to another country? I have to explain that most Olympians and Olympic gold medallists come out of the NCAA system, so if that is a motivation, then perhaps they need to look at that option," he says.

"When we do get athletes to commit to the NCAA, they are in their early 20s. They might have benefitted more had they decided to go a couple of years earlier. If they have already started university in India, it becomes even more of a challenge because that removes some of their eligibility to compete in the NCAA (Collegiate athletes are permitted to compete for five years in the NCAA, but this goes down if they have attended university previously)," says Siddhi.

There are cultural misgivings as well. Tejaswin says a number of vegetarian athletes have concerns about whether they will be able to manage a change in diet. Others are

unsure whether they will be able to manage their study workload or even whether they have the academic background to apply in the first place. The first concern, he says, is misplaced.

"I understand the question of vegetarianism because I've gone through it myself. But you have to understand that we are in a cosmopolitan world. Eventually, you have to get out there and see what all is available," he says.

The fact that many Indian athletes tend to prioritise their sports at the expense of their academic advancement is potentially a bigger challenge. This isn't as much of an issue at the time of recruitment. Thurnhoffer says, "A lot of kids have the concern that they need to have a certain grade if they want to be recruited. But that's not always the case. Your SAT (Standard Aptitude Tests) scores aren't necessarily important. If you are an 8m long jumper or a 45-second 400m runner, a lot of coaches will be willing to overlook your SAT scores, even if you